IAE PARIS — SORBONNE BUSINESS SCHOOL · IDGP ACADEMY

Benchmarking Study

The follow-up to the Digital Tool Appraisal: one reference decoded, and the six-month roadmap across the three capability gaps.

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Companion to the Digital Tools & Benchmarking reading notes

This printed version is for working by hand. The same study is fillable online and exports to PDF, which is the version to hand in.

Contents

Not what the reference's number is, but what routine produces it — and what this organisation would have to accumulate before that routine could run here.

ONE **What you need in order to answer** 4

TWO **The instrument** 6

THREE **Reading the result** 10

FOUR **Sources** 11

> **“Nobody here knows” is a finding.** The study restates your answers; it does not score them.

Benchmarking fails less often for lack of effort than for looking at the wrong thing. GM toured NUMMI for twenty years and copied everything that could be photographed; the other plants stayed where they were. This instrument asks the question a site visit skips: not *what is their number*, but *what routine produces it* — and what this organisation would have to accumulate before that routine could run here.

It is the module's follow-up assignment, done by the same group on the tool it appraised in the room, and it is better done with a week of thought than with ten minutes of room time. Part One sets out the ideas each field relies on, Part Two is the instrument, and Part Three says how to read what comes out. **"Nobody here knows" is a legitimate answer** — and usually the most useful one.

ONE

What you need in order to answer

Everything below is developed in Part Five of the afternoon's reading notes. This page carries only what the fields depend on.

The method, before the critique

Phase	What it requires	Where it is usually skipped
1 · Plan	Decide what to benchmark — a process, not a department — choose a comparator, and settle how the measure will be defined before anybody goes looking.	The comparator is chosen for prestige rather than comparability.
2 · Collect	Gather data on both sides with the same definition, and record the conditions under which each figure was produced.	Their figure comes from a published source; ours is calculated differently.
3 · Analyse	Establish the size of the gap and — far more importantly — the practice that produces it.	The gap is quantified and the practice never identified. This is the fatal one.
4 · Adapt	Set targets, change the practice, embed it, re-measure.	Targets are set from the gap with no change to the practice that would close it.

After Camp (1989), from the Xerox programme that made the practice general.

Choosing the comparator

Four kinds, in increasing order of difficulty and of payoff. **Internal** — another unit of the same organisation: easiest access, smallest ceiling. **Competitive** — a direct rival: the most wanted, the least available, and the one most likely to converge the industry. **Functional** — the same function in another industry. **Generic** — a structurally analogous process in an unrelated setting: Xerox fixed its warehouse by studying a catalogue retailer, and the distance is what made the practice visible.

Why best practice resists transfer

Mechanism	What it predicts	What it changes in your study
Internal stickiness Szulanski, 1996	Transfer fails for reasons of knowledge, not motivation — even between two units of the same firm.	Budget for absorption, not only acquisition. Who here can receive this, and what must they already know?

Causal ambiguity Lippman & Rumelt, 1982	Even the source may not know which elements produce its result.	Do not ask the reference what it does. Ask what it stopped doing, and what it would never give up.
Interdependence Rivkin, 2000	A partial copy performs worse than no copy.	Identify the bundle, not the practice. If you cannot adopt the set, adopting one element may cost you.
Time compression Dierickx & Cool, 1989	Accumulated capability cannot be bought quickly at any price.	Ask how long the reference took. Plan for that order of magnitude, or change the objective.

What the visit sees, and the rule underneath

Spear and Bowen's four rules are the decoding key — the tacit operating rules a site visit never surfaces unless the visitor arrives knowing they exist. Work is specified to content, sequence, timing and outcome; every connection between a customer and a supplier inside the organisation is direct and unambiguous; every pathway is pre-specified and single; and every improvement is a refutable hypothesis, mentored, at the lowest possible level. Where a visit sees standard forms, a ticketing platform, automated routing and monthly retrospectives, the study has to name the rule each one serves.

> **THE STRATEGIC CAVEAT**
>
> Benchmarking is imitative by construction: practised well by everyone, it converges an industry onto one operating model, and competition collapses into price (Porter, 1996). That is not an argument against it — it is an argument for knowing which of two things you are doing. On a **qualifier**, convergence is precisely the goal. On an **order winner**, imitation is the wrong instrument.

TWO

The instrument

Work on the tool the group appraised in the room. If you used the Digital Tool Appraisal in this browser, its name is carried over. Answer from what you can evidence; **"nobody here knows"** is a finding, not a gap in your answer.

Benchmarking Study

Three sections · the module's follow-up assignment · better with a week of thought

1 · What is being benchmarked

The tool or capability this study concerns

Usually the tool appraised in the room.

What it is called

The gap that made you look outside

The indicator or symptom, as precisely as you can: "approvals take three weeks", "our forecast error is twice the reference's". This is phase 1 — what is being compared, and how it is measured.

Is the gap on a qualifier or on an order winner?

From the morning: a qualifier is a threshold — its absence eliminates you, its presence attracts nobody. An order winner is what makes a customer choose you.

- [ ] Qualifier — reaching the threshold is the goal, and converging with others is fine
- [ ] Order winner — what we want is a difference, not parity
- [ ] Not sure

2 · The reference — who already does this well

Pick one organisation, or one published standard, that does what this tool is meant to achieve better than you do. The question is not what their number is, but what routine produces it — and what you would have to build before that routine would work here.

The reference — which organisation, or which standard?

The most useful reference is often outside your industry.

An organisation, or a published standard

What kind of comparator is it?

- [ ] Internal — another unit of our own organisation
- [ ] Competitive — a direct rival
- [ ] Functional — the same function in another industry
- [ ] Generic — an analogous process in an unrelated setting
- [ ] A published standard or survey

Are the two sets of numbers comparable?

Most benchmarking failures are arithmetic before they are strategic: the same process boundaries on both sides, normalised for scale and mix, with the conditions recorded. A survey percentile says whether a gap exists, not what produces it.

- [ ] Yes — same definition and boundaries, normalised, conditions recorded
- [ ] Partly — same definition, but scale, mix or conditions differ
- [ ] No — their figure is published, ours is calculated differently
- [ ] We have not checked

What does the reference do that you do not?

The practice, not the indicator. "They are 30% faster" is a number; "they review the representation quarterly with a named owner" is a practice. Ask what they stopped doing, and what they would never give up.

Would you be copying an asset, a process, or a rule-in-use?

- [ ] A — an asset we would buy
- [ ] P — a process we would document and copy
- [ ] C — a way of working that lives in people's habits, which we would have to build

What else does it depend on — the rest of the bundle?

The practices that make this one work at the reference. A partial copy can perform worse than no copy.

What would have to be true here for that practice to work?

What would our people need to already know, or already be able to do? Practices fail to transfer for reasons of knowledge far more often than of motivation — including between two units of the same company.

How long did the reference take to build it?

- [ ] Months
- [ ] A few years
- [ ] A decade or more
- [ ] Unknown — nobody here knows

Adopt, adapt or discard

- [ ] Adopt — conditions are already in place
- [ ] Adapt — translate it to our context
- [ ] Discard — it depends on conditions we do not have and cannot reasonably accumulate

3 · Capability gaps and the six-month roadmap

The reference concerns one practice. A roadmap concerns the organisation. Name the three capabilities whose absence most constrains performance — capabilities, not products: "a single authoritative home for schedule dates" rather than "a new PPM system" — then place each on the two axes that decide sequence. **How much does closing it matter?** High if it moves something customers choose you for, or removes a constraint that keeps recurring. **Can it be closed with what exists today?** High if the people, the data and the authority to change the process are already in hand. **When would work on it start?** — not finish: a roadmap is sequenced by starts.

Gap 1

The capability that is missing, in one line

Gap 1 — how much it matters, whether it can be closed now, and when it starts

- [ ] High
- [ ] Medium
- [ ] Low

Gap 2

The capability that is missing, in one line

Gap 2 — how much it matters, whether it can be closed now, and when it starts

- [ ] High
- [ ] Medium
- [ ] Low

Gap 3

The capability that is missing, in one line

Gap 3 — how much it matters, whether it can be closed now, and when it starts

- [ ] High
- [ ] Medium
- [ ] Low

What has to be true by the end of month two?

One sentence, measurable. A roadmap whose first checkpoint cannot be stated is a list of intentions with dates attached.

THREE

Reading the result

The study has no score either. It produces three things worth looking at.

- **Whether you found a practice or only a number.** If section 2 names an indicator and no routine, phase 3 of the method has not been done — and phase 3 is the one that matters.
- **Whether what you would copy is A, P or C.** Assets and documented processes travel. Rules-in-use do not travel by observation: they have to be built, and how long the reference took is the honest estimate of how long that takes.
- **Whether the roadmap starts where it can win.** High value and high feasibility belong in the first two months, because an early demonstrated result buys the patience the harder items will need. High value and low feasibility scheduled first is the commonest way a roadmap loses its sponsor.

A filled-in example on Zillow Offers — the reference and the roadmap that follow its appraisal — is on the Worked examples page.

FOUR

Sources

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